

2026 World Cup Predictions

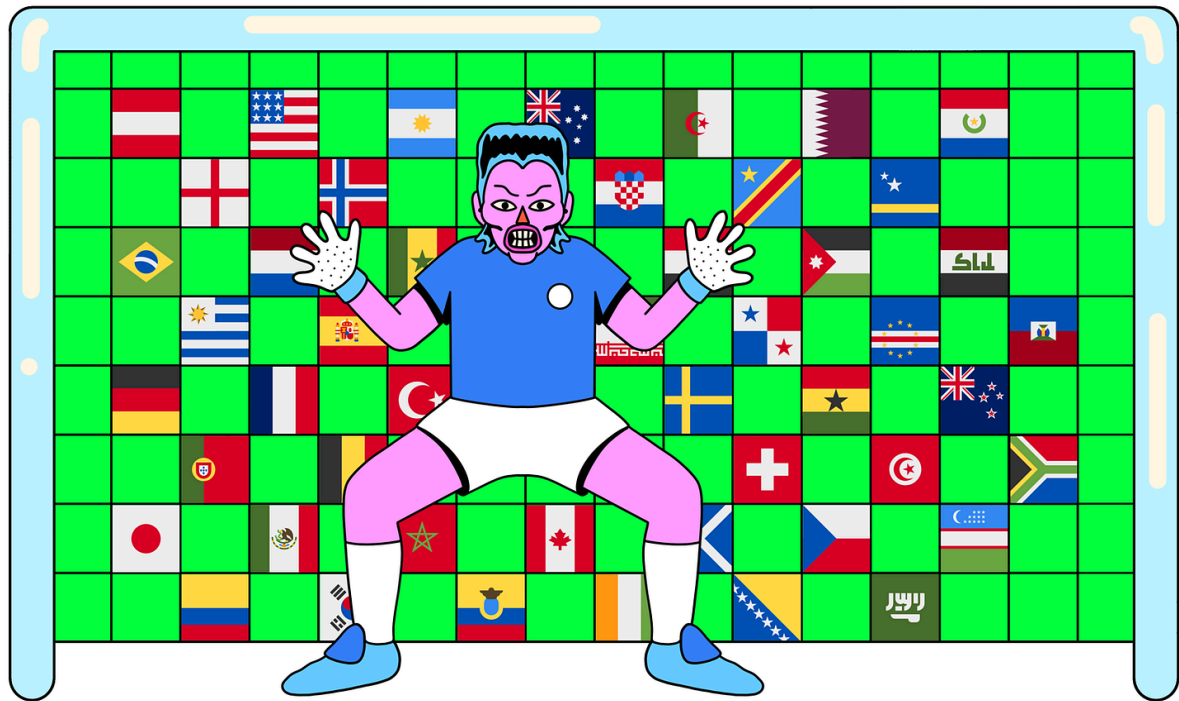


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⚽ The latest World Cup projections: June 18, 2026

Portugal not good enough while England thrives

We’re through MD1 of the 2026 World Cup — Match Day 1 — meaning that every team has now played one game. And as much as we’d advise against updating your priors based on a sample size of one, there seem to be some differences in quality.

In contrast to Spain’s draw with Cape Verde on Monday, for example, where they were clearly the better side but couldn’t get the job done, Portugal looked far from a top-flight contender in their 1-1 draw with DR Congo, controlling possession but lacking cohesion and constantly

vulnerable to counter-attacks. It's probably not going to prevent them from advancing, but this is a team that PELE is a little skeptical about because international results haven't always matched the talent. Colombia's 3-1 win over Uzbekistan in the other Group K match doesn't help either.

PELE is bullish on Argentina relative to the market, conversely, and I'll admit I don't *quite* get why this feels like a contrarian position. They won the last World Cup. They won [Copa America](#). They finished with easily the best record in CONMEBOL qualifying. And while they're probably not the most "talented" team in the world, they have Leo Messi, who scored a hat trick last night (!) to tie the all-time World Cup goal record.

It's certainly been an entertaining tournament so far, though. England are in great shape to advance after a confident 4-2 win over Croatia, and although Ghana scored a thrilling late goal to beat Panama, the match did not inspire a lot of confidence in the Group L competition.

Our model adjusts its odds after each game, playing out the rest of the tournament 100,000 times while giving teams credit (or blame) for their performance so far. We don't want to overpromise, and we have a small team, so expect one update per day, but you may occasionally see intraday updates after important matches. We've also been [tracking injury updates](#), which are becoming a problem for some of the frontrunners.

Because there are *many* charts and this page will update frequently, it is [best viewed on the web](#). For our methodology, see [here](#).

See also: [PELE International Football Rankings](#).

So, who's gonna win the World Cup? While our model doesn't deviate *too* much from the conventional wisdom, we don't have teams in quite the same order. Each time we run the model, we play out 100,000 simulated World Cups, accounting for the difficulty of each team's draw, meticulously calculating tiebreakers, and even the possibility of a dark-horse contender getting hot and unexpectedly being in top form.¹ Let's look at the PELE ratings and some specific adjustments that we've made to them for the World Cup.

Part I. Team and group ratings



Our baseline PELE ratings are adjusted in several ways for the tournament. First, we account for differences between PELE's algorithmically calculated rosters and the [actual, announced World Cup rosters](#). Thus, we correct for the impact of injuries or otherwise unexpected player absences.[2](#)

Second, we update each team's rating based on the quality of their performance relative to PELE's expectations for each match. For instance, while Mexico beat South Africa 2-0 in the opening game, this result was pretty much what PELE expected so it doesn't produce much of a revision to the overall ratings. And third, we adjust for home-field advantage on a match-by-match basis.[3](#) The factor is customized for each team: as it happens, the U.S., Canada and *especially* Mexico[4](#) have above-average home-field advantages.

You can see the impact of some of PELE's advanced features. Norway, for instance, receives a boost from Erling Haaland because PELE accounts for player market values.

You might have noticed that our table introduced some mascots: a fox[5](#) () for Group F, for instance. (By the way, that's a [hedgehog](#) , not a porcupine, for Group H.) We figured that might be helpful because with 12 groups this year, the group stage could be roughly as confusing as the [Tokyo Subway Map](#). Here are all the groups, with their mascots, along with the pre-tournament composite ratings[6](#) for each one.

Group ratings and the Group of Death

Average* roster-adjusted PELE rating by group at the start of the tournament, including home-field bonus for hosts

 GROUP A 1782 -132 1 Mexico 2 South Korea 3 Czechia 4 South Africa	 GROUP B 1772 -142 1 Canada 2 Switzerland 3 Bosnia & Herz. 4 Qatar	 GROUP C 1849 -65 1 Brazil 2 Morocco 3 Scotland 4 Haiti	 GROUP D 1845 -69 1 United States 2 Turkey 3 Paraguay 4 Australia
 GROUP E 1842 -72 1 Germany 2 Ecuador 3 Cote d'Ivoire 4 Curacao	 GROUP F 1850 -64 1 Netherlands 2 Japan 3 Sweden 4 Tunisia	 GROUP G 1773 -141 1 Belgium 2 Egypt 3 Iran 4 New Zealand	 GROUP H 1843 -71 1 Spain 2 Uruguay 3 Saudi Arabia 4 Cape Verde
 GROUP I 1914 LEADER 1 France 2 Norway 3 Senegal 4 Iraq	 GROUP J 1865 -49 1 Argentina 2 Austria 3 Algeria 4 Jordan	 GROUP K 1862 -52 1 Colombia 2 Portugal 3 Dem. Rep. Congo 4 Uzbekistan	 GROUP L 1861 -53 1 England 2 Croatia 3 Panama 4 Ghana

Teams ranked #1-4 within each group by individual PELE rating. Negative numbers show points behind the leader (Group I). Skulls denote the three toughest groups.
*The fourth-ranked team gets 50% weight in the group average; others get full weight.

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Some groups are tougher than others, particularly France's Group I (🦎), which also features Norway and Senegal. Under the old format, this would be a proverbial [Group of Death](#), but now all three teams have a chance to get through. The United States' Group D (🐬) is also a little tougher than reputed, with no elite teams but also no easy outs. Canada and Mexico have among the easier draws in the tournament, however.

But let's be honest: 32 teams out of 48 advancing makes for a forgiving format. (The eight highest-ranked of the 12 3rd-place finishers will go to the knockout stage along with the winner and runner-up from each group.) Yes, we put a lot of work into precisely incorporating FIFA's [complicated tiebreaker rules](#) into our simulations. (Head-to-head results now take precedence over goal differential.) But no country that has any pretension of being a soccer superpower has a good excuse *not* to advance. The expansion from 32 to 48 teams also lowers the floor significantly, with teams like Uzbekistan, Cape Verde and Curacao potentially providing for easy group-stage fodder and possibly yielding a higher-scoring tournament.⁷

Let's take the rest of this in phases. We've accounted for pretty much every detail that we can think of, from how teams' odds of advancing will change based on the results of each group stage game to the biggest upsets in World Cup history:

- [Part II: Group stage projections](#)
- [Part III: Knockout stage projections](#)
- [Part IV: Road to the knockout stage](#)
- [Part V: Match projections](#)
- [Part VI: Team track records and historical data](#)

Ratings and forecasts will be updated at the end of each match day⁸. As a heads-up, we'll show all of you some data from the first four groups as a preview, but most of this incredibly detailed analysis is reserved for paying subscribers. (Paid subscribers will also get access to our [full suite of PELE ratings](#) and our forthcoming midterm election forecasts.)

Part II. Group stage projections



As we've said, 12 groups are a lot, especially with as much detail as we're going to show you. So let's pair our mascots off into squads of four, starting with Groups A through D, which include the three co-hosts. Here are the latest results of our 100K simulations. Once the tournament gets underway, we'll hardcode any actual results and simulate the rest of the World Cup from there.

We've opted to show you a lot of detail here because of FIFA's [complicated tiebreakers](#). Here's what determines group stage placement, in precise FIFA order:

- Points: 3 for a win and 1 for a draw
- Head-to-head results between tied teams
- Goal differential
- Goals scored

- Fair play points (FPP), or basically yellow cards and red cards: the fewer, the better for advancement (appropriately, this is the yellow column in the chart)
- Finally, the [FIFA rankings](#)

Mexico (with its huge home-field advantage) and Brazil are clear favorites in Groups A and C, respectively. In fact, Mexico is now almost certain to advance after their 2-0 win against South Africa in the opener. But the positions behind them may be a scramble with the tiebreakers mattering. The U.S. and Canada began as more like co-favorites in their groups along with Turkey and Switzerland — Canada's Group B is rather weak — although the U.S.'s superior performance in their opener have put "us" in a good position. So what exactly are their odds of advancing? That's in our next table:

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